



Still in need of confronting: Shadow education and its implications in the sustainable development goals

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Private tutoring
Regulations
SDG4
Shadow education
Social inequalities

ABSTRACT

Recent decades have brought global expansion of private supplementary tutoring, widely known as shadow education, with enrolment rates in some countries and at some grades now exceeding 80%. Shadow education maintains and exacerbates social inequalities despite government efforts through the Education for All (EFA) agenda and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) to reduce inequalities. Patterns vary, but in most countries shadow education receives inadequate policy attention in part because governments feel that it is beyond their remit and/or that they lack regulatory capacity. The paper argues for improved data collection for clarity on the extent, nature and implications of shadow education, and for stronger attention to regulations. One component of these regulations should focus on teachers, to specify the circumstances in which teachers may (not) provide tutoring. Another component should focus on commercial providers of shadow education, regulating them not only in the ways that other businesses are regulated but also with specific focus on educational domains.

In 2007, UNESCO's International Institute for Educational Planning (IIEP) hosted a Policy Forum entitled *Confronting the Shadow Education System: What Government Policies for what Private Tutoring?*. The event focused on fee-charging supplementary tutoring in academic subjects outside school hours. It employed the shadow metaphor on the grounds that much tutoring content mimics that in schooling. Participants in the event included policy-makers and planners from Ministries of Education, staff of international agencies, personnel from the private sector, and university researchers. The Policy Forum led to a book (Bray, 2009) that was subsequently translated into 20 languages.² The book and/or the related work has also been cited in publications by such bodies as UNESCO (e.g. 2015a, 2021), the OECD (2014), UNICEF (Borkowski et al., 2021), and the United Nations Special Rapporteur on the Right to Education (Singh, 2015).

The UNESCO-IIEP work contributed to, and was part of, increased global attention to shadow education. This attention has been stimulated by expansion of the phenomenon and by increased awareness of implications for social inequalities and other dimensions of the Education for All (EFA) movement established in 1990 and extended in 2000, and of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) set in 2015. However,

attention remains inadequate. A few governments, most notably in China, have taken strong policy stances, yet many others have laissez faire approaches. Partly because of data inadequacies, international agencies also still give the theme less attention than it needs.

This paper commences by framing the issues within the SDG agenda. It then outlines the scale and nature of shadow education before turning to drivers of tutoring supply and demand. As noted in the next section, some negative dimensions of shadow education can be ameliorated through regulations, though careful balances are needed. The final section looks ahead to ways in which shadow education can be confronted more successfully in different contexts.

1. Framing the issues

Advocates point out that private supplementary tutoring strengthens academic achievement and human capital, and assists both low achievers to keep up with their peers and high achievers to stretch further. Advocates add that tutoring provides employment, and can help schooling by providing types of tailored support that schools cannot provide because they are constrained by large classes and other factors.

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² These languages are Arabic, Armenian, Azeri, Bengali, Chinese, Farsi, French, Georgian, Hindi, Kannada, Korean, Mongolian, Nepali, Polish, Portuguese, Sinhala, Spanish, Thai, Urdu, and Uzbek.

These perspectives can have validity, but need balance. Shadow education is more likely to be accessed by students who are already performing well than by low achievers; and since shadow education is fee-charging, it is more readily available in both quantities and qualities to prosperous families than to lower-income counterparts. This feature undermines the first part of the fourth Sustainable Development Goal (SDG4), i.e. “Ensure inclusive and equitable quality education...” (UNESCO, 2015b, p.20).

Additional challenges include the potential for tutoring to undermine aspects of schooling. Problems arise when talented teachers leave schools for the tutorial sector, and when teachers who remain in schools provide tutoring outside school hours and then pay more attention to their private lessons than to their regular teaching. Also, students may be tired from the combination of schooling plus tutoring, and may pay less attention during schooling because they respect their tutors more than their teachers. Finally, the pedagogic and curricular approaches of tutors may conflict with those of teachers; and when some students receive tutoring but others do not, disparities are exacerbated within classrooms.

2. The scale and nature of shadow education

The scale of shadow education may be illustrated by statistics from a variety of countries across world regions.:

- **Asia:** In South Korea, 63% of students across all grades received private tutoring in 2022 (KOSIS, 2023). In Cambodia, a 2019/20 national dataset indicated enrolment rates of 24% among primary, 57% among lower-secondary, and 77% among upper-secondary students (Cambodia, 2020, p.65). An Indian survey in rural West Bengal found in 2022 that 63% of Grade 1 students were receiving shadow education, with the proportion reaching 76% in Grade 8 (Pratham, 2023, p.250); and urban enrolment rates were presumably even higher (Sengupta, 2022).
- **Europe:** In England, 11% of students aged 11-16 surveyed in 2022 were receiving shadow education, and 30% (46% in London) had done so at some time (Cullinane and Montacute, 2023, p.16). In Greece, 90% of Grade 12 students surveyed in 2017/18 were receiving shadow education (Katsillis, 2020, p.146).
- **Latin America:** In Brazil, a 2017/18 survey of students in Grades 10-12 found that 35% attended tutorial classes and 31% received individual tutoring (Galvão, 2022, p.71). In Chile, among Grade 8 students surveyed by the Trends in International Mathematics and Science Study (TIMSS) in 2019, 23% were receiving tutoring in mathematics and 9% were doing so in science.³
- **Middle East and North Africa:** In Egypt, a 2018 national survey found that 73% of Grade 9 students were receiving private tutoring (Morano Olmedilla, 2022, p.150). In Qatar, a 2018 survey found shadow education enrolment rates of 38% in Grade 8 and 56% in Grade 12 (Sellami, 2019, p.12).
- **Sub-Saharan Africa:** In Mauritius, 81% of Grade 6 students were estimated in 2013 to be receiving shadow education, while proportions in Botswana and Malawi were 35% and 14% (Bray, 2021, p.17), and there is every reason to assume that such rates have been maintained and even increased. Comparable 2019 figures were 22% in Senegal, 20% in Cameroon, and 16% in Togo (Bray and Baba-Moussa, 2023, p.9).

These snapshots show significant enrolment rates not only in high-income countries such as Qatar and England but also in low-income ones such as Cambodia and Senegal.

Underlying the numbers is considerable diversity in forms and subjects of tutoring. While much tutoring is one-to-one, other tutoring is in small groups, full classes or even large lecture theatres. Alongside, tutoring is increasingly provided online – a trend accelerated by lockdowns during the COVID-19 pandemic (see e.g. Bray, 2021, p.35; Hajar and Karakus, 2023, p.6; Zhang, 2023, p.11). Mathematics and languages dominate because they are core subjects and support other domains, while such subjects as history, geography and religion are commonly in less demand.

Other diversity is in the amounts, seasons, providers, and qualities of tutoring. The durations of tutoring received may vary from just a few hours immediately before the examination season to 12 or more hours each week during both term-time and holidays. The providers include teachers, as mentioned above, and also university students, retirees and other informal workers. Importantly, providers also include companies of varying sizes and capacities. Some companies serve only their local neighbourhoods while other operate nationally and even internationally. Companies also vary in their orientations, with some focusing mainly on technology, others providing matching services for families and tutors, and most providing direct services on their own premises, in other public spaces such as cafes and libraries, and/or in the homes of tutees. The quality of tutors may also vary widely, with some trained for their roles but others untrained (Bray, 2023; Bray and Hajar, 2023; Zhang, 2023).

3. Drivers of supply and demand

The expansion of private tutoring is linked to the spread of neoliberalism and increased acceptability of the notion that education can be a marketable service (Verger et al., 2016). In this context, entrepreneurs identify commercial opportunities, and the widespread practice of teachers offering tutoring no longer raises so many eyebrows.

The major underlying driver of demand across the globe is social competition. Families view shadow education as the mechanism to secure social mobility or, in the case of families already occupying high social strata, to maintain their positions. In this competitive environment, shadow education may be viewed as part of good parenting and even as a mechanism to avoid ‘losing at the starting line’. Related are patterns, for example in Cambodia, where private tutoring is necessary to receive the full curriculum (Le et al., 2022, pp.37–38). This problem is especially acute when teachers ‘save’ components of the school curriculum to tutor their existing students after the official hours.

Ironically, demand for shadow education has been fuelled by the successes of the EFA movement. In previous eras, low socioeconomic groups were less likely to aspire even for complete secondary education, let alone for post-secondary education. Yet the achievement of universal primary education led to pressure for universal lower-secondary education, and then in turn for much-expanded upper-secondary and post-secondary education. With this expansion, socio-economic groups that in former eras had faced glass ceilings now find that upper-secondary and post-secondary education is within reach. However, systems have remained stratified, with the question changing from *whether* it is possible to receive education at each level to *which institutions* can be accessed. Thus, shadow education is still needed to pass examinations with sufficient marks for entry to prestigious institutions and, especially at the post-secondary level, to prestigious programmes within those institutions.

The educational expansion has in turn impacted on government budgets. Not only have overall enrolments increased, but they have especially done so at secondary and post-secondary levels that have greater unit costs. Further, while governments are pressed to expand secondary and post-secondary education, they are also pressed to expand pre-primary provision (e.g. UNESCO, 2000, p.19; 2015b, p.7). Moreover, while the United Nations and related bodies have long stressed the importance of fee-free schooling at the level of compulsory education, the SDG agenda enjoins governments to provide fee-free

³ Some tutoring may have been free of charge, but it may be assumed that most was fee-charging. Source: TIMSS and PIRLS Database <https://timssandpirls.bc.edu>.

education for a full 12 years of schooling and additionally encourages at least one year of free and compulsory quality pre-primary education (UNESCO, 2015b, p.7). The financial pressures have required reductions in unit costs by cutting teachers' salaries, textbooks, facilities, and other components. This pattern has a pair of consequences. First the quality of schooling has been threatened, requiring families to seek supplementary tutoring to bridge the gap; and second, teachers feel that their incomes are inadequate to meet their family needs, requiring them to seek additional incomes. Private tutoring is among the most obvious ways to secure additional incomes; and if teachers neglect their regular duties to place more focus on their private work, the quality of public education falls further.

Within this overall picture, moreover, are slogans promoted by the United Nations that sound positive but in practice are shallow and inconsistent with reality. One example is in the report of the United Nations Secretary-General entitled *Our Common Agenda* (United Nations, 2021). It opens with 12 key proposals that are "in line with and designed to accelerate the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals". Among these 12, the first (p.6) is "Leave no one behind". Yet the reality in the competitive world is that most families struggle hard to leave others behind, and use shadow education as an instrument to do so. The EFA and SDG agendas have raised the bar, requiring more shadow education in the intensified environment for longer durations of education than was the case for previous generations.

4. Regulatory responses

Within the overall picture are instructive variations in government attitudes towards shadow education. Many Ministries of Education in practice see themselves as Ministries of Schooling and consider the shadow sector beyond their responsibility. Companies that provide shadow education may be regulated as businesses by the Ministries of Commerce or equivalent, but other dimensions of shadow education may be treated with *laissez faire* approaches, particularly in low-income countries that lack personnel to devise and enforce regulations.

In striking contrast is the tough approach taken in China. In the initial decades from the 1980s, the Chinese authorities resembled counterparts elsewhere with *laissez faire* attitudes. Then, as the tutorial sector expanded, the government restricted and in 2015 prohibited private tutoring by serving teachers (Zhang, 2023, p.64). The authorities also tightened regulations on companies, leading in 2021 to a crack-down on the sector (China, 2021). The policy was ostensibly driven by concern about study loads. Noting the burdens of both school-administered homework and shadow education, the authorities sought alleviation through a 'double reduction' policy. The policy declared that academic tutoring for students during the period of compulsory education could only be delivered on a not-for-profit basis on weekdays during term-time from the end of schooling until 9.00 pm. With systematic follow-up, the Minister of Education stated 15 months after the policy announcement that the respective numbers of online and offline tutorial companies had been reduced by 87% and 96% (Huai, 2022).

The Chinese approach was possible in a country with strong political leadership and machinery to follow up at sub-national levels. However, it tackled supply rather than demand, and much tutoring went underground at higher prices (Liu, 2023). This process maintained elements of social stratification, and moved tutoring further into the shadows.

In this context, South Korea's experience deserves recall. As noted during the UNESCO-IIEP Policy Forum (Bray, 2009, pp.50–54), in that country questions about both study burden and social stratification had been raised since the 1950s but shadow education had continued to expand. In 1980, 26.2% of high-school pupils, 15.3% of middle-school pupils, and 12.9% of elementary-school pupils were receiving tutoring. Seeking to resolve the problem, in that year the government banned all academic private tutoring. Again, however, much tutoring went underground at higher prices, and the authorities were forced by stages

to relax the prohibition. The relaxation commenced in 1984 with permission for low achievers to receive extra lessons in school from teachers, and with senior high-school students allowed to attend foreign-language institutes during the winter holidays. Further relaxations were officially permitted in 1988, 1989, 1991 and 1996 (Bray, 2009, p.51). Finally the policy was completely abandoned because it had been challenged in the constitutional law courts where in 2000 it was declared an infringement of human rights. In these circumstances the authorities redoubled efforts to make private tutoring unnecessary by improving schooling, but shadow education rebounded with vigour. Even before the legal decision, enrolment rates were considerably above their 1980 levels. Over the next decade they jumped further and, as noted above, the 2022 participation rate was 63% across all grades (KOSIS, 2023). This experience raises the question whether Chinese patterns will follow a similar path.

Meanwhile, however, a strong case can be made for regulations of some sort even if perhaps not as extreme as those in China and South Korea. For example, governments may consider prohibiting teachers from tutoring their existing students, and perhaps even from tutoring any students registered in their schools. Governments may also require proper registration of tutorial enterprises and then set requirements for premises, accounting, taxation, etc. Some authorities have gone further with stipulations about tutors' qualifications, class sizes, fees and curriculum, though these matters are not straightforward. Authorities also face additional challenges with increased volumes of tutoring being conducted online (Zhang, 2023). Online tutoring may have lower unit costs, and can reach rural households distant from urban centres offering face-to-face provision. However, it is less easily inspected and monitored by government regulators, especially since much online tutoring may even be across national boundaries.

5. Conclusions

When the EFA goals were set in 1990, they focused almost entirely on schooling, albeit with mention of alternative nonformal strategies to meet learning needs. Shadow education was not on the agenda, chiefly because it was not at that time a significant issue outside a few countries such as Greece, Mauritius and South Korea. Shadow education was still not on the agenda a decade later when the EFA goals were revised. By 2015, awareness of the scale and implications of shadow education was stronger, but still the topic did not penetrate the official SDG discussions.

This paper commenced with the 2007 UNESCO-IIEP Policy Forum entitled *Confronting the Shadow Education System*. The number of translations of the book from that event, and citations in reports by UNESCO, the OECD, UNICEF, and the United Nations Special Rapporteur on the Right to Education, suggest that to some extent the message has been heard. Yet shadow education still needs confronting. Many governments have *laissez faire* approaches despite the far-reaching implications of private tutoring for equity and access. In some societies, private tutoring has become so widespread that it is perceived as quasi-compulsory and raises the question whether official statements about fee-free education are just a façade.

For most parts of the world, an important starting point for confrontation lies in data collection. The statistical snapshots presented at the beginning of this paper are indeed just snapshots, and very few countries have data comparable to those for schooling even in a single year let alone over time. Among components of needed data are quantities and qualities of shadow education received by students in different grades across genders, socio-economic groups, and urban/rural residence. Further data must focus on the subjects and locations in which tutoring is received, the modes of tutoring, and the identities and training of tutors. The core document for the September 2023 SDG Summit reported that progress had been made with data for SDG monitoring, and that the number of indicators in the global database had increased from 115 in 2016 to 225 in 2022 (United Nations, 2023, p.6). The document added a call (p.29) to expand budgets for further data

collection, and a strong case can be made for including shadow education in the focus.

Meanwhile, however, enough data are available to show the significance of shadow education. Some of these data come from national household surveys, as in India (Pratham, 2023), while others come from national surveys of students for example in Qatar (Sellami, 2019) and England (Cullinane and Montacute, 2023). They can be supplemented by smaller studies that include qualitative alongside quantitative analyses. Cross-national surveys, such as those administered by PASEC in Francophone Africa also provide valuable data, albeit to date with methodological limitations (Bray and Baba-Moussa, 2023).⁴ These studies show considerable expansion of shadow education during recent decades. Since the launch of the SDGs in 2015 the scale of private tutoring has continued to expand, for some participants facilitated by technological developments and perceptions of learning loss caused by school closures during the COVID-19 pandemic. The topic could at least have been recognised in the documentation for the United Nations' Transforming Education Summit (United Nations, 2022) and in the SDG4 performance indicators produced by the UNESCO Institute for Statistics (e.g. UIS, 2022).

Some of the expansion of shadow education may be viewed positively. For example, Pratham's national surveys in rural India found that the proportions of children in Grades 1–8 receiving shadow education increased from 26.4% in 2018 to 30.5% in 2022 (Pratham, 2023, p.49), in part because of household demand during school closures caused by COVID-19. In Bihar, the reported enrolment rate in shadow education had jumped from 61.6% to 71.5%, and in Jharkhand the jump was from 36.9% to 45.2% (Pratham, 2023, p.55). The Pratham analysts (2023, p.20) considered it “entirely possible” that the supplementary help from tutoring restricted the learning loss in these states, particularly in mathematics. Yet other reports around the world have been less enthusiastic about the increased incidence of shadow education during the COVID-19 pandemic, highlighting in particular the social inequalities and in many cases also querying the effectiveness of shadow education especially when provided by untrained personnel (Zhang, 2023). Commentators also note a possible ratchet effect from increased enrolment rates during the crisis that to some extent are likely to be sustained thereafter (see e.g. Hajar and Karakus, 2023, p.4).

Yet while this paper has in general lamented inadequate government confrontation of shadow education, it has also expressed ambivalence about the most obvious contemporary example of confrontation, in China. The policy launched in 2021 is arguably too extreme, and at least in the short run has killed aspects of supplementary tutoring that could be considered beneficial as ways for families to help low achievers to keep up with their peers and to stretch high achievers further. The policy has also increased the burden on teachers. First they are now required to do more to support their pupils in academic work, and second they must provide extra-curricular activities at the end of the school day in order to keep children constructively occupied while their parents are engaged in wage-earning employment and other activities. The dramatic closure of the vast majority of tutorial centres also cut that sector from the labour market, and as such had an economic impact. And since much tutoring went underground at higher prices, significant social inequalities remained. Noting parallels with South Korea after shadow education was prohibited in 1980, the paper has pointed out that the policy tackled supply rather than demand, and in the long run may not be sustainable.

The question then becomes what might be a more balanced approach worth heeding elsewhere. First, schooling needs to have adequate quality so that parents are not forced to seek shadow education because of glaring shortcomings in schooling. Among factors requiring attention

will be sufficient teachers' salaries so that teachers do not need extra incomes to meet their families' needs.

Beyond these immediate measures will be broader consideration of social inequalities. A fundamental driver of shadow education lies in competitive forces, themselves shaped by inequalities and the role of education in social stratification and/or mobility. The slogan “Leave no one behind” does not fit realities insofar as middle and upper socio-economic classes indeed wish to retain distance from lower classes, and use shadow education among other instruments to do so. Nevertheless, the United Nations core document for the September 2023 SDG Summit does have appropriate aspiration in its stress (p.30) that “the world must act to close gaps and improve the well-being of people farthest behind, and thus contribute to stability and resilience globally”. The way forward lies not only in specific strategies for the education sector but also in broad policies to reduce social inequalities. These policies can be facilitated in both design and implementation by stronger public discussion based on improved data. Along the way, education authorities can learn much from comparative analysis of regulatory approaches, recognising that different approaches may be needed in different cultural contexts.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Mark Bray: Conceptualization, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

Acknowledgement

Work on this paper was supported by the UNESCO Chair in Comparative Education at the University of Hong Kong. The author also thanks the managing editor and the anonymous reviewers for their helpful comments.

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⁴ PASEC is the Programme d'Analyse des Systèmes Éducatifs de la CONFEMEN (PASEC). It operates under the auspices of CONFEMEN – i.e. the Conférence des ministres de l'Éducation des États et gouvernements de la Francophonie – the Secretariat of which is located in Senegal.

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